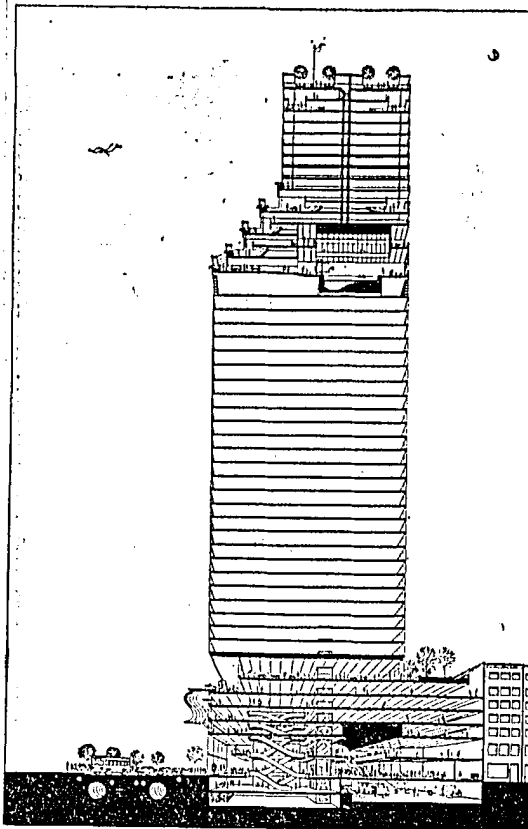




This cross section of a Fifth Avenue building shows how special district provisions allow lower floors to be devoted to retailing, middle floors to offices and top floors to apartments and a swim club.

New York zoning bonus could work here

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

During the late Lindsay administration in New York, the first real effort in an American city was made to find some way to get public control over the way new buildings were being designed.

A survivor of that heroic period has now written a book about it. The author is Jonathan Barnett, the book is called "Urban Design and Public Policy," and despite the dry title, it's pure dynamite. It's probably the best single book round for anyone who wants to get a fix on where our cities are heading.

Barnett is a realist and his book is a fascinating, profusely illustrated, case-by-case account of his experiences as a member of the Urban Design Group in Lindsay's government.

This group, which became probably the most influential group of architects ever to hold office in an American city, began simply as Barnett and four friends who had the chutzpah, at age 30 or so, to offer their services to the new mayor and get accepted.

They quickly found a model for what they wanted to do in the form of a somewhat infamous New York law called the Plaza Bonus. This was a provision passed in 1961

that worked this way: If a developer doing a new office building was willing to give up part of his land for a public plaza, he could get in return the right to build more floors than the law normally allowed.

Developers had leaped at the Plaza Bonus and obligingly created a witless sprawl of plazas that quickly spread through midtown Manhattan like mange.

But awful as they were, each new windy, uninhabited plaza proved that the bonus was working. The lesson seemed to be clear: here was a way you could shape the city by

persuasion instead of force.

Barnett and his colleagues grabbed the bonus concept and applied it in new and startling ways.

When office buildings threatened to displace the theaters from Times Square, a bonus of extra floor space was offered to builders who included a new theater in their buildings.

When Fifth Avenue, too, seemed about to go the office-building route, a bonus-point system was

worked out to encourage a whole new kind of building, one that would stack a department store on the ground, offices above and apartments on top.

The formula was always the same: up to 20 percent extra floor area in return for some public amenity. Bonuses were offered for arcades, for second-floor sidewalks, for direct subway connections, for anything the planners wanted.

More inventively yet, in cases where owners of historic buildings wanted to tear their property down so as to erect larger, more profitable new buildings, the city offered the owner

the option of transferring his "development rights" (i.e., the amount of floor area the zoning allowed him to build onto some other site, or even selling them. Thus the landmark could be saved without penalizing its owner. One result was a whole landmark district, the South Street Seaport Museum.

A lot of cities, including Boston, are now looking at the idea of zoning bonuses. Developers tend to like the idea because it makes life a little more predictable — it spells out what the city will let you do and what it wants in return.

Politicians often dislike it for the same reason: it leaves less room for dealing.

Some doubts do linger from Barnett's book. Does it really make sense, for instance, to prop up that probably hopeless institution, the big Broadway theater? Isn't that an attempt to freeze the past? Or are second-floor sidewalks really such a good idea?

But such questions are really the whole point. To forces us to define more carefully than before just what we want the city to be. And that's good.